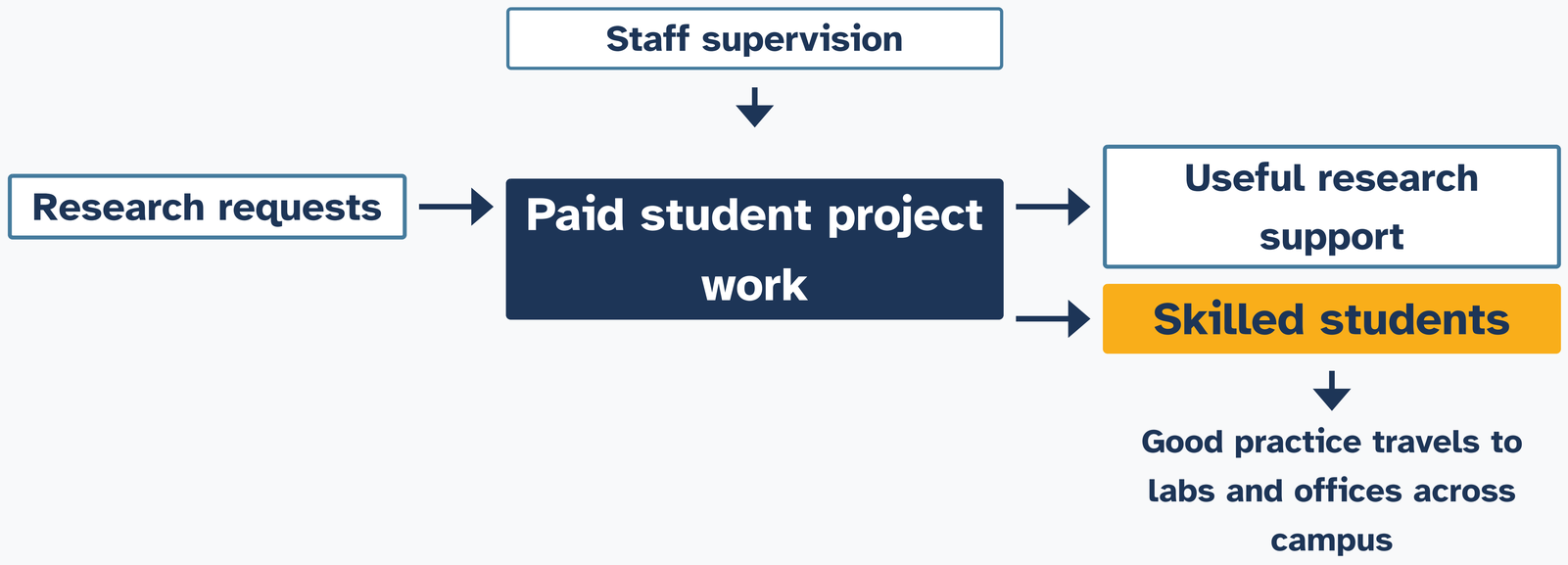
Is the DataSquad Model For You?

Paula Lackie, Oliver Hall, Tim Dennis, Leigh Phan
Carleton College DataSquad | UCLA Library Data Science Center DataSquad

Students are not just the tool. They are a beneficial product of the service.

Campuses need more data and software support than they have staff to give, and students have few ways to gain real experience. The work is little known, especially to students from underrepresented backgrounds. Students who want that experience can close the gap, and perhaps widen who thrives in this work.



Paid learning, useful service

Students are paid employees, supervised by library or department staff. They help researchers with data from wrangling to reproducibility.

Who is on a squad

- Student **data analysts** do the hands-on work.
- A student **project manager** triages requests.
- Student **technical writers** document projects.
- **Staff** supervise, fund, and sustain the squad.

Limits we keep

Squads help with a researcher's data. They do not change the research questions, tutor, or break confidentiality.

What it costs in pace

Student availability, the academic calendar, onboarding, review, and graduation handoffs all slow the work. More students take on more varied projects but need more oversight. Handbooks, templates, and staff carry continuity.

Practices as projects need them

Examples sit on a spectrum. Not every client needs a public repository.

CARLETON

Election-news scraper. Nine students started, extended, or used it from 2021 to 2024 to collect broadcast transcripts for a political science project. The tool outlasted the students who began it.

UCLA

wbcheck. Two students began this Carpentries lesson checker in 2023. Staff rebuilt it in 2026 with AI assistance. It has 48 documented rules, tests, a BSD-3 license, and a citation file crediting the original authors.

CARLETON

Language placement dashboard. The project ran longer than any student would stay, so the squad sketched the database and chose heatmaps for the development team to build.

UCLA

UC OSPO education site. Two students built the lesson pages and search for a catalog of 55 open source lessons.

Where a project calls for it, students add run instructions, a dependency list, one test, or a citation file. We plan to track whether clients keep them.

What we know

- Data / analytics / consulting (11 of 19)
- Software / engineering / IT (4 of 19)
- Research / graduate school (2 of 19)
- Nonprofit / public sector (2 of 19)

19 UCLA former student employees we located, by current job category (public profiles, 2026). Descriptive, not a placement rate. Carleton tracing is in progress.

What adopting takes

- Paid student positions and a wage budget
- A supervisor with time to review
- Onboarding, and somewhere to keep documentation
- A plan for turnover

Start one

The starter kit at **datasquad.info/join** covers roles, a confidentiality agreement, onboarding, and request tracking. Ask us for sample job descriptions.